

Minoan art

The Minoan civilization flourished on the Mediterranean island of Crete from c.2700–1450 BCE, developing a unique style of art. Named after the legendary King Minos, they cultivated a thriving trade around the Mediterranean, and built magnificent palaces. Their religion focused on female deities and officiators, and their frescoes differentiated genders by colour: men's skin is reddish-brown, while women are white.

In the Early Minoan (c.2700–2200 BCE), frescoes and ceramics featured flowing linear patterns including spirals, triangles, crosses and fish-bone motifs. In the Middle Minoan (up to 1500 BCE) vessels were usually made with the potter's wheel and often decorated with stylized marine creatures. By the Late Minoan (to 1000 BCE), vibrant flowers, plants, sea life and animals proliferated on pottery. Frescoes were painted while the plaster was still wet, so pigments adhered to the walls, and fluid brushstrokes and curving lines suggested movement. Soft stone carvings served both decorative and practical uses.



'Prince of the Lilies' fresco from the palace of Knossos, c. 1550 BCE